

"I feel comfortable in the world I am familiar with. There's a sense of freedom in knowing the life that runs around you."

THE PHONE IS THE LIFELINE for Geeta Ghosh of Kolkata. She has not relented so far to her daughter's invitation to find home with her family in Delhi.



moving into pay-and-stay homes that offer an honourable lifestyle. Consider the 53-odd senior citizens who live in old-age home, Godhuli, in Delhi. "Almost all our members came here on their own," points out O.N. Gupta, once a vice-president with the Jindal Group and now a member. He lost his wife 25 years back, raised his three children single-handedly. "They are all over the world and doing very well," he smiles. Post-retirement, he bid goodbye to his corporate lifestyle and opted for one where he would not have to face the hassles of running a house-

hold. In Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Kerala and Karnataka, 'day care' centres for the elderly are turning out to be a great hit among working couples.

The younger generation is looking for inspiration. Sarasa Vasudevan, the former chief of Thai Airways in Bangalore, might just be one such. Even in college, she had enjoyed spending time with the inmates of the Little Sisters of the Poor in Langford. Now, she has milled together the combined energies of her mother, mother-in-law and her teenage daughter to think up a home for the aged, spread

across 22,000 sq ft at a whopping Rs 90 lakh. The project, slated for completion in two years, will be a 60-member spot for parents to spend a few days, or the rest of their time, as they wish. "We want to make it as self-sufficient as possible," she says.

Meanwhile, the Government is mulling over the proposed Bill. If passed, it will slap hefty fines and/or imprisonment to neglectful children. They will have to return inherited property in case of mistreatment. But not everyone is equally excited. "A relationship-based society as ours is trying to cope with changes through a rule-based Anglo-Saxon system," says R. Vaidyanathan, professor of Finance and Control, Indian Institute of Management, Bangalore. Will parents actually complain, given various social pressures? "The government in the bedroom can be as disastrous as the government in the board room," he adds. Such measures can at best be a palliative. "Social capital—family ties and community linkages—is still strong in India. This must be enhanced and enriched instead of deriding it in the name of modernisation."

Till such time, it is the "empty nest" syndrome in reverse gear for the old and infirm in India. 'Home' is not where the heart is, 'life' is work and worry, 'love' is children's voice on the telephone, 'affection' is their message on the Internet, 'caring' is the nurse they engage when ill and 'responsibility' is the money they pay through the bank account. What's the way out for generation-now? Throwing money at the problem (better hospitals, better doctors, anything to avoid facing the alternative)? Or the other extreme of micromanaging parents' lives (buying the groceries, doing the laundry)? The truth, that parents who nurtured them once are now the ones who need nurturing, won't set them free, but recognising it might open up new possibilities. And unlike child-rearing, there are no Dr Spocks out there with time-tested advice. The road ahead is likely to unfold as a series of personal journeys, for which there are few reliable road maps and precious little reassurance.

with Rahul Tewari, Stephen David, Swagata Sen and Rupesh Paul